The Congo: A Study of the Negro Race

By Vachel Lindsay

INTRODUCTION

Vachel Lindsay is often ignored in analogies of twentieth-century poetry because he is judged to be exceptionally reactionary in his racism. However, when Lindsay justified his pacifism during World War I, he said he would rather have died "of his own will mounting a blazing pyre . . . by the side or in place of some black who had not trial by jury" than in the trenches." He held a conviction that "the only way to end lynching would be to thrust yourself into the thick of such a mob and make the men slay you instead of the Negro. Was Lindsay too controversial for America nearly 100 years ago? Is he too controversial for America today . . . or does he perhaps provide and insight into the cultural history of African Americans which is too seldom recognized? The Congo by Vachel Lindsay.

I. Their Basic Savagery

Fat black bucks in a wine-barrel room,

Barrel-house kings, with feet unstable,

A deep rolling bass.

Sagged and reeled and pounded on the table,

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Pounded on the table,

Beat an empty barrel with the handle of a broom,

Hard as they were able,

Boom, boom, BOOM,

With a silk umbrella and the handle of a broom,

Boomlay, boomlay, boomlay, BOOM.

THEN I had religion, THEN I had a vision.

I could not turn from their revel in derision.

More deliberate. Solemnly chanted.

THEN I SAW THE CONGO, CREEPING THROUGH THE BLACK,

CUTTING THROUGH THE FOREST WITH A GOLDEN TRACK.

Then along that riverbank

A thousand miles

Tattooed cannibals danced in files;

Then I heard the boom of the blood-lust song

A rapidly piling climax of speed and racket.

And a thigh-bone beating on a tin-pan gong.

And "BLOOD" screamed the whistles and the fifes of the warriors,

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"BLOOD" screamed the skull-faced, lean witch-doctors,

"Whirl ye the deadly voo-doo rattle,

Harry the uplands,

Steal all the cattle,

Rattle-rattle, rattle-rattle,

Bing.

Boomlay, boomlay, boomlay, BOOM,"

With a philosophic pause.

A roaring, epic, rag-time tune

From the mouth of the Congo

To the Mountains of the Moon.

Death is an Elephant,

Shrilly and with a heavily accented metre.

Torch-eyed and horrible,

Foam-flanked and terrible.

BOOM, steal the pygmies,

BOOM, kill the Arabs,

BOOM, kill the white men,

HOO, HOO, HOO.

Like the wind in the chimney.

Listen to the yell of Leopold's ghost

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Burning in Hell for his hand-maimed host.

Hear how the demons chuckle and yell

Cutting his hands off, down in Hell.

Listen to the creepy proclamation,

Blown through the lairs of the forest-nation,

Blown past the white-ants' hill of clay,

Blown past the marsh where the butterflies play: --

"Be careful what you do,

All the "o" sounds very golden. Heavy accents very heavy. Light accents very light. Last line whispered.

Or Mumbo-Jumbo, God of the Congo,

And all of the other

Gods of the Congo,

Mumbo-Jumbo will hoo-doo you,

Mumbo-Jumbo will hoo-doo you,

Mumbo-Jumbo will hoo-doo you."

II. Their Irrepressible High Spirits

Rather shrill and high.

Wild crap-shooters with a whoop and a call

Danced the juba in their gambling-hall

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And laughed fit to kill, and shook the town,

And guyed the policemen and laughed them down

With a boomlay, boomlay, boomlay, BOOM.

Read exactly as in first section.

THEN I SAW THE CONGO, CREEPING THROUGH THE BLACK,

CUTTING THROUGH THE FOREST WITH A GOLDEN TRACK.

Lay emphasis on the delicate ideas. Keep as light-footed as possible.

A negro fairyland swung into view,

A minstrel river

Where dreams come true.

The ebony palace soared on high

Through the blossoming trees to the evening sky.

The inlaid porches and casements shone

With gold and ivory and elephant-bone.

And the black crowd laughed till their sides were sore

At the baboon butler in the agate door,

And the well-known tunes of the parrot band

That trilled on the bushes of that magic land.

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With pomposity.

A troupe of skull-faced witch-men came

Through the agate doorway in suits of flame,

Yea, long-tailed coats with a gold-leaf crust

And hats that were covered with diamond-dust.

And the crowd in the court gave a whoop and a call

And danced the juba from wall to wall.

With a great deliberation and ghostliness.

But the witch-men suddenly stilled the throng

With a stern cold glare, and a stern old song: --

"Mumbo-Jumbo will hoo-doo you." . . .

With overwhelming assurance, good cheer, and pomp.

Just then from the doorway, as fat as shotes,

Came the cake-walk princes in their long red coats,

Canes with a brilliant lacquer shine,

And tall silk hats that were red as wine.

With growing speed and sharply marked dance-rhythm.

And they pranced with their butterfly partners there,

Coal-black maidens with pearls in their hair,

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Knee-skirts trimmed with the jassamine sweet,
And bells on their ankles and little black feet.
And the couples railed at the chant and the frown
Of the witch-men lean, and laughed them down.
(O rare was the revel, and well worth while
That made those glowering witch-men smile.)
The cake-walk royalty then began
To walk for a cake that was tall as a man
To the tune of "Boomlay, boomlay, BOOM,"

With a touch of negro dialect, and as rapidly as possible toward the end.

While the witch-men laughed, with a sinister air,
And sang with the scalawags prancing there: --
"Walk with care, walk with care,
Or Mumbo-Jumbo, God of the Congo,
And all of the other
Gods of the Congo,
Mumbo-Jumbo will hoo-doo you.
Beware, beware, walk with care,
Boomlay, boomlay, boomlay, boom.
Boomlay, boomlay, boomlay, boom,

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Boomlay, boomlay, boomlay, boom,
Boomlay, boomlay, boomlay,
BOOM."

Slow philosophic calm.

Oh rare was the revel, and well worth while
That made those glowering witch-men smile.

III. The Hope of their Religion

Heavy bass. With a literal imitation of camp-meeting racket, and trance.

A good old negro in the slums of the town
Preached at a sister for her velvet gown.
Howled at a brother for his low-down ways,
His prowling, guzzling, sneak-thief days.
Beat on the Bible till he wore it out
Starting the jubilee revival shout.
And some had visions, as they stood on chairs,
And sang of Jacob, and the golden stairs,
And they all repented, a thousand strong
From their stupor and savagery and sin and wrong

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And slammed with their hymn books till they shook the room

With "glory, glory, glory,"

And "Boom, boom, BOOM."

Exactly as in the first section. Begin with terror and power, end with joy.

THEN I SAW THE CONGO, CREEPING THROUGH THE BLACK

CUTTING THROUGH THE JUNGLE WITH A GOLDEN TRACK.

And the gray sky opened like a new-rent veil

And showed the apostles with their coats of mail.

In bright white steele they were seated round

And their fire-eyes watched where the Congo wound.

And the twelve Apostles, from their thrones on high

Thrilled all the forest with their heavenly cry: --

Sung to the tune of "Hark, ten thousand harps and voices".

"Mumbo-Jumbo will die in the jungle;

Never again will he hoo-doo you,

Never again will he hoo-doo you."

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With growing deliberation and joy.

Then along that river, a thousand miles

The vine-snared trees fell down in files.

Pioneer angels cleared the way

For a Congo paradise, for babes at play,

For sacred capitals, for temples clean.

Gone were the skull-faced witch-men lean.

In a rather high key -- as delicately as possible.

There, where the wild ghost-gods had wailed

A million boats of the angels sailed

With oars of silver, and prows of blue

And silken pennants that the sun shone through.

'Twas a land transfigured, 'twas a new creation.

Oh, a singing wind swept the negro nation

And on through the backwoods clearing flew: --

To the tune of "Hark, ten thousand harps and voices".

"Mumbo-Jumbo is dead in the jungle.

Never again will he hoo-doo you.

Never again will he hoo-doo you."

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Redeemed were the forests, the beasts and the men,

And only the vulture dared again

By the far, lone mountains of the moon

To cry, in the silence, the Congo tune: --

Dying down into a penetrating, terrified whisper.

"Mumbo-Jumbo will hoo-doo you,

Mumbo-Jumbo will hoo-doo you.

Mumbo . . . Jumbo . . . will . . . hoo-doo . . . you."

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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